

TAMIL NADU & KARNATAKA ORIGIN

Medu Vada

Crispy Deep-Fried Lentil Doughnuts
The Crispiest Bite at a South Indian Breakfast Table

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Medu Vada

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Medu Vada

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

South India's Favourite Crunch

If the idli is South India's most gentle breakfast, the medu vada is its most exuberant one. Golden, crisp-shelled, ring-shaped, and fried to a deep amber, the medu vada is the breakfast that everyone reaches for first. In Tamil, 'medu' means soft — a reference to the pillowy interior that contrasts so dramatically with the crackling crust.

Records of vada-like fried lentil preparations appear in Tamil Sangam literature dating back over two thousand years, making it one of the oldest continuously prepared foods in South India. The distinctive ring shape — formed by pushing a thumb through the batter before frying — evolved practically, ensuring even cooking throughout and allowing the vada to absorb sambar when soaked.

Today, the medu vada is ubiquitous at Udupi restaurants, temple prasadam trays, and wedding breakfasts from Chennai to Bengaluru. It is the dish that defines the concept of 'tiffin' — the South Indian tradition of a cooked, hot breakfast taken seriously as a meal in its own right.

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Served as temple prasadam across Tamil Nadu and Karnataka, prepared without onion or garlic in temple kitchens. An essential component of the classic 'idli-vada' combo that anchors every South Indian breakfast restaurant menu. Traditionally eaten by soaking in sambar — a preparation called 'sambar vada' where the vada absorbs the liquid like a sponge. Offered during Pongal, Karthigai Deepam, and other Tamil festival breakfasts.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

20m	4–6h	25m	4 (12 vadas)	Medium
ACTIVE PREP	SOAK TIME	FRY TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Wet grinder or high-powered blender
- Deep kadai or wok (for frying)
- Kitchen thermometer (recommended, target 175°C / 350°F)
- Wire rack or mesh strainer for draining
- Small bowl of water (for wetting hands while shaping)
- Spider skimmer or slotted spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Batter can be refrigerated (unfried) for up to 12 hours — keep it tightly covered so it doesn't dry out or over-ferment. Fried vadas are best eaten within 15 minutes. If needed, reheat in a 180°C oven for 5–6 minutes to restore crispness; microwaving makes them soft and chewy. Do not freeze the batter — freezing destroys the texture.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the medu vada

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Urad dal (split, dehusked)	1 cup	200 g	1 katori
Green chillies, finely chopped	2	2	2
Black peppercorns, coarsely crushed	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Fresh curry leaves, torn	12–15	12–15	12–15
Fresh coriander, finely chopped	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp
Fresh ginger, grated	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste
Water (for grinding)	2–4 tbsp	30–60 ml	as needed
Oil (for deep frying)	as needed	as needed	as needed

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Urad dal is non-negotiable here — no other lentil gives the same airy, fluffy texture. Find it at any South Asian grocery store, sold as 'urad dal split' or 'white urad dal.' Black peppercorns can be supplemented with a pinch of red chilli powder for heat. If fresh curry leaves are unavailable, dried ones give a fraction of the flavour; frozen curry leaves from South Asian stores are a much better substitute.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Soaking & Grinding the Batter

01 SOAK THE URAD DAL

Rinse the urad dal thoroughly under cold water until the water runs clear. Cover with at least twice its volume of cold water and soak for 4–6 hours, or overnight. The dal will swell to nearly double its size and turn pale and soft.

Chef tip. Cold water soaking slows fermentation and gives better control over the batter texture. Avoid hot or warm water.

02 DRAIN THOROUGHLY

Drain the soaked dal completely in a colander and shake off excess water. The drier the dal when it enters the grinder, the better the batter — excess water makes the batter thin and difficult to shape.

03 GRIND TO A FLUFFY BATTER

Add the drained dal to a wet grinder or strong blender. Grind, adding water one tablespoon at a time, until the batter is completely smooth, thick, and visibly fluffy. The total water added should be no more than 3–4 tablespoons. The batter is ready when a spoonful dropped into a bowl of water floats to the surface.

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Soaking & Grinding the Batter, continued



Chef tip. Grind in pulses in a blender rather than continuously — this builds air into the batter. A wet grinder gives superior results for professional-quality vadas.

04 MIX IN THE AROMATICS

Transfer the batter to a large bowl. Add the green chillies, crushed pepper, torn curry leaves, coriander, ginger, and salt. Using clean hands, beat the batter vigorously for 2–3 minutes in a circular motion — this incorporates additional air and ensures even distribution of aromatics.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Soaking & Grinding the Batter, continued

COOKING CHECKPOINT

Properly prepared batter is thick, holds its shape on a spoon, smells fresh and lightly herbal, and a small ball dropped in water floats immediately. If it sinks, the batter needs more beating, or was ground too thin.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Shaping & Frying the Vadas

05 HEAT THE OIL

Pour at least 3 inches / 7 cm of oil into a deep kadai. Heat over medium-high heat to 175°C (350°F). Use a thermometer for accuracy — oil too hot burns the outside before the inside cooks; oil too cool makes the vadas absorb excess oil and turn greasy.

06 SHAPE THE VADAS

Keep a bowl of water nearby. Wet your palm and fingers thoroughly. Take a lemon-sized ball of batter (about 2 tablespoons) and place it on your wet palm. Flatten it into a disc about 1 cm thick. Press your thumb through the centre to create a clean hole, then gently slide the vada off your palm directly into the hot oil.

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Shaping & Frying the Vadas, continued



Chef tip. The hole is not decorative — it ensures the thick centre cooks through before the outside over-browns. A hesitant or slow slide into the oil flattens the vada; slide in with confidence.

07 FRY TO DEEP GOLDEN

Fry 3–4 vadas at a time without crowding the oil. Fry for 3–4 minutes on the first side until golden brown, then flip and fry for 2–3 minutes on the second side. The vadas should be a deep amber colour all over — pale vadas are under-cooked.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Shaping & Frying the Vadas, continued

08 DRAIN ON A WIRE RACK

Remove the fried vadas with a slotted spoon and drain on a wire rack placed over a tray — not on paper towels, which trap steam and soften the crust. Serve immediately.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Draining vadas on paper towels is the single most common reason homemade vadas lose their crispness within minutes. A wire rack lets air circulate, keeping the crust intact for up to 10 minutes.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served immediately with coconut chutney and a bowl of hot, well-spiced sambar for dipping.
- A drizzle of ghee over the sambar alongside is the classic accompaniment.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Sambar Vada Style

- Submerge two vadas in a generous bowl of sambar and allow to soak for 2–3 minutes — the vada absorbs the sambar while retaining some texture.
- Top with finely chopped raw onion and fresh coriander.

Restaurant Presentation

- Vadas presented whole with a small pour of sambar at the table, chutney on the side.
- Upscale restaurants garnish with microgreens and a droplet of tamarind gel.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

The Floating Test

- The float test is not optional — it is the only reliable indicator of batter quality. If your batter doesn't float, grind it longer or beat it by hand for another 3 minutes before testing again.
- Batter that is too wet never passes the float test; add no more water after grinding.

Temperature Control

- Maintain oil at a steady 175°C throughout frying. After each batch, allow the oil temperature to return to 175°C before frying the next.
- A digital probe thermometer is the most important tool for consistent vadas.

SHAPING TRICKS

If you find hand-shaping difficult, place a small square of wet banana leaf or plastic sheet on your palm — the vada slides off more cleanly.

Professional vada makers in restaurants can shape and release a vada in under 3 seconds — consistency comes from practice, not a secret technique.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

85 kcal	3.5 g	10 g	3.5 g	1.2 g
CALORIES (PER VADA)	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with preparation method and serving size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

No common allergens detected in the ingredient list. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Masala Vada	Made with chana dal (split chickpeas) rather than urad dal, coarser in texture with whole spices — a popular Tamil Nadu street snack.
Sambar Vada	Finished vadas soaked in hot sambar — a complete dish in its own right, typically eaten with a spoon.
Dahi Vada	Vadas soaked in chilled, seasoned yogurt with tamarind chutney — a North Indian adaptation, served as a chaat.
Keerai Vada	Green-hued vadas from Tamil Nadu with blanched spinach (keerai) worked into the batter — extra nutrition without compromising crunch.

My vadas turned flat when I slid them into the oil – what went wrong?

The batter was likely too thin, or not enough air was beaten in. Perform the float test before frying. Also check that you slid the vada into the oil quickly — hesitation while sliding causes the hole to close and the disc to flatten.

The inside is raw even though the outside is golden – how do I fix this?

The oil temperature was too high. Lower the heat to medium and fry slower — 3–4 minutes per side at 165–170°C gives thorough cooking without over-browning.

Can I make the batter the night before?

Yes, but refrigerate it immediately after grinding. Cold-retarded batter fries just as well. Do not leave at room temperature overnight — it will over-ferment and turn too sour.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Is medu vada gluten-free?

Yes, naturally gluten-free. Made only from urad dal with no wheat or flour additions.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Urad dal	split, skinned black gram, the base of idli, dosa, and vada batters across South India.
Kadai	a deep, round-bottomed Indian cooking vessel used for deep frying; a wok makes a good substitute.
Tadka	a tempering of spices bloomed in hot oil, used as the final flavour layer in many South Indian dishes.
Sambar vada	vadas fully submerged in sambar; a complete breakfast dish, not just a dipping accompaniment.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Medu Vada

20m ACTIVE PREP	4–6h SOAK TIME
25m FRY TIME	4 (12 vadas) SERVINGS
Medium DIFFICULTY	

MEDU VADA

Urad dal	200 g
Green chillies	2
Black peppercorns	3 g
Fresh curry leaves	12–15
Fresh coriander	8 g
Fresh ginger	4 g
Salt	6 g
Water	30–60 ml
Oil	as needed

METHOD

01 **Soak the urad dal.** Rinse the urad dal thoroughly under cold water until the water runs clear.

02 **Drain thoroughly.** Drain the soaked dal completely in a colander and shake off excess water.

03 **Grind to a fluffy batter.** Add the drained dal to a wet grinder or strong blender.

04 **Mix in the aromatics.** Transfer the batter to a large bowl.

05 **Heat the oil.** Pour at least 3 inches / 7 cm of oil into a deep kadai.

06 **Shape the vadas.** Keep a bowl of water nearby.

07 **Fry to deep golden.** Fry 3–4 vadas at a time without crowding the oil.

08 **Drain on a wire rack.** Remove the fried vadas with a slotted spoon and drain on a wire rack placed over a tray — not on paper towels, which trap steam and soften the crust.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Urad dal	200 g	☐ Green chillies	2
☐ Black peppercorns	3 g	☐ Fresh curry leaves	12–15
☐ Fresh coriander	8 g	☐ Fresh ginger	4 g
☐ Salt	6 g	☐ Oil	as needed

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